Chapter Seventy-Two

The End of the World

Between 1338 and 1353,
the plague arrives

IT BEGAN JUST WEST OF CHINA.

The tenth Yuan emperor, Kublai Khan's great-great-great-grandson Toghon Temur, sat on the Chinese throne. He had been crowned in 1333, aged thirteen. For eleven years he had been the passive ruler of a top-heavy, bureaucrat-stuffed, unevenly taxed empire, run for him by his chancellors.[1]

Five years after his coronation, an obscure little village below Lake Issyk-Kul began to die.* We know this only from the headstones found in the village graveyard; hundreds of them date from the years 1338 and 1339. "This is the grave of Kutluk," one reads. "He died of the plague with his wife."[2]

No contemporary accounts trace the spread of the illness in the next six years, but plenty of chroniclers record other disasters: drought and famine in the Huai river valley, torrential flooding rains in the provinces at Canton and Houkouang, locusts in Honan, an earthquake that carved a new lake into the Ki-Ming-Chan mountain range. Meanwhile, sickness seems to have moved silently west, along the trade routes between the Yuan cities and the markets of India. In 1344, an army from Delhi, marching south to put down a rebellion in Ma'bar, was wiped out by a "pestilence"; the Arab traveler Ibn Battuta, visiting the southeastern city of Madurai, discovered a lethal infection sweeping through it. "Whoever caught it," he wrote "died on the morrow, or the day after."[3]

By 1346, the Western world knew that something horrible had spread